

So we give that feedback -- that developers may want to use it in this way and we should allow our product to be used in the same way too. We should not say that the Google way is the only way to use the product. This is what we influence.

The engineering team will choose what tech stack it feels is the best for that particular problem and product, for example, Java, Python, frameworks, containers, etc.

Google is very cognizant about security and privacy and we ensure that every library we use -- third party or open source -- is vetted, secure and has gone through all the penetration testing and scans.

The development team has a choice from this buffet of approved libraries and languages, and is free to choose whatever it wants. So, as developer advocates, we don't get involved with this, but do help ensure the final product is successful.

Q. What are the biggest challenges you have faced as a DevRel expert?

A. The scaling is definitely one. India has so many developers and reaching out to everyone is impossible, but it is important to help users. We expect feedback from developers and would like them to raise issues that need to be addressed. That kind of feedback definitely helps us to fine tune the way we do things. We also definitely want people to realise that we are here to help them understand the topic. That's basically where I am stepping in and trying to help out. It's not a very difficult thing, but the more effort we put in and the more we connect with developers, the better it will be.

Q. What is the path for career growth in a DevRel role?

A. Different companies have modelled the role differently. DevRelers are expected to be technical. They need to know their products. People who are experts in containers, Kubernetes and building systems with containers could

probably go into a solutions architect kind of role in that space, depending on how deep they are into it. But if somebody was just creating client libraries, that person may not have got the needed exposure in architecture and designing systems. So a solutions architect may not be the right path in that case.

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There are multiple streams of growth. One is the sales engineering side, where you are spending time, working with people, learning their problems, and explaining technology.

At Google, we are expected to be really hands-on and have technical depth, and hence we are close to technology and code. In such cases, growing as an engineer can also be a career path.

Because you are influencing the product - understanding the user's needs and impacting the way the product should be built - product management is another possible path.

If you enjoy teaching, maybe you can start your own consulting firm and teach people. There are lots of interpretations of what DevRelers do, but there are definitely multiple paths that you can grow towards.

And within the DevRel role itself, one can expand the scope of impact. For instance, if I did something for

India and it worked out, I could probably take it to other regions and make this more global. So that way I am growing in the role itself, by increasing the scope of my influence.

Q. How can one move into a DevRel role from an engineering function?

A. If somebody is an extrovert, it's a great role to move into, but may not be as conducive for someone who is extremely introverted. For example, if someone has stage fear, events can be avoided. But there are many other ways one can work with developers, like writing articles, blogs, or maybe recording a YouTube video.

Communication and empathy are critical across all roles. A frustrated user may tell me a product is terrible. But if I go to my product managers and say this product isn't good, they will ask me for more information on what happened. What failed? What did the user want to do with the product? So there's a way in which I need to give feedback too. I put it up to my team stating that these are some of the things that are working the way the product has been built, but are probably different from the way the user expected them to work. Maybe this feature is not reliable. Are we monitoring this? What is our expectation in terms of reliability? All this needs good internal and external communication skills in oral or written forms.

The other aspect is the intention to spread knowledge. If you want to educate developers then you should take up such a role. This was important for me and that's what led me into this DevRel journey. I have grown as a software architect and as a tech lead. I mentor developers and engineers to ensure that they know how to use technology and match it to problem statements and requirements. **END** 

*The complete interview is available online at opensourceforu.com **END** *